CENTRE FOR FILM AND MEDIA STUDIES
COURSE WORK COVER SHEET

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TOPIC: Creative Assignment
DUE DATE: 25 October 2024
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Lacuna.

EXT. SOCCER FIELD - LATE AFTERNOON

The golden hues of the setting sun stretch across the soccer field. The game is over, and a group of players lounges around, catching their breath, laughing, and talking. THABISO (18) chimes in with his own stories. The conversation is about girls, all the guys are fully engaging, each one louder than the next.

PLAYER 1

(teasing)

So, Thabiso... do have your eye on anyone? Skare fitlhela.

[So, Thabiso do you have your eye on anyone? Don’t hide it from us.]

THABISO

Nah, not really, I just want to focus on myself right now, don’t want any distractions.

The others laugh and continue the conversation until COACH(43), a broad-shouldered man, steps in. His energy is commanding but familiar, and he grins widely, inserting himself into the conversation.

COACH

(grinning)

Ahh, le bua kabanyana, huh? You guys don’t waste any time. Thabiso, you’re quiet what’s your deal? Got any girls on your mind?

[Oh, you’re talking about girls huh? You guys don’t waste any time. Thabiso, you’re quiet what’s your deal? Got any girls on your mind?]

The question hangs in the air for a moment. His smile fades slowly. A faint non-diegetic heartbeat sound underscores his unease.

THABISO

(awkwardly)

Aowa, coach, nna ke sharp.

[No, coach, I’m good.]

The group chuckles, but Coach isn’t done. He leans in closer, his voice dropping just slightly, his smile shifting into something else.

COACH

You know...I can always tell when someone is a little...different.

The laughter around the group slows, and the focus fully shifts to Thabiso. Thabiso feels his heart skip a beat, his eyes darting downward, trying to understand what the coach means.

COACH

(smirking)

Yhaa...I know a gay guy when I see one.

The words slice through the air like cold wind. Thabiso freezes, his mouth dry, as he glances up at the coach. Everyone else shifts uncomfortably, the atmosphere suddenly turns tense, but no one says a word. Coach chuckles, but the tone is sharper now.

COACH

(teasing, but firm)

A’re tshepe gore ke wrong, I wouldn't want to find out that one of my boys is like that. That’d be... unfortunate.

[Let’s hope I’m wrong though, I wouldn't want to find out that one of my boys is like that. That’d be... unfortunate.]

COACH

(Moving his hand slowly behind Thabiso’s back, trying to ease Thabiso)

Mara ska wara ntuana, nna kao tshepa,a never o dire nthwe tse jalo akere?

[But I trust you man, you wouldn’t do me like that, right?]

For a moment, the world around him becomes distant the laughter of his teammates, the fading sounds of the field. All of it

fades into a dull hum, and suddenly, all he feels is the pressure of that hand and the words hanging in the air.

THABISO (V.O.)

(having a moment of emotional clarity and anxiety)

Why did he do that, what just happened?

PLAYER 2

(Laughing, trying to lighten the mood)

Come on, Coach, udlala ka T-Man. [Come on Coach, you're messing with him.]

But Thabiso doesn't hear it. He forces a smile that doesn't quite reach his eyes, his mind already pulling away, retreating.

THABISO

I, uh...gotta go.

He stands abruptly, his heart racing. The group falls silent as the sound of his steps fills the field, each step faster than the last, until he's almost running from them, running from the joke, from the touch, from everything.

PLAYER 1

(watching him leave)

Keng jwale?

[What's wrong with him?]

PLAYER 2

(shrugs)

Aketse mfana.

[I don't know bro.]

The group remains silent, watching Thabiso disappear in the fading light, his shoulders hunched, his mind spinning with thoughts he can't quite hold onto.

CUT TO

INT. THABISO’S BEDROOM - NIGHT

The room is dim, lit only by the soft glow of a bedside lamp. Only a faint ticking clock fills the silence. His mind is racing, replaying Coach’s words, the hand on his back, the ticking grows louder as his thoughts spiral. But the unease isn’t just about the coach, it’s something deeper, something old.

THABISO(V.O.)

(his voice shaking and about to crack, trying to hold back his tears)

Everything is fine, it was just a gentle pat on the back, it’s nothing serious, don’t overthink it, he was just making conversation with everyone, it didn’t mean anything, but Dad...

CUT TO

FLASHBACK - INT. LIVING ROOM - DAY (YEARS AGO)

A younger Thabiso, about 7 or 8 years old, sits on his father’s lap. His father’s large hands rest on his small shoulders. At first, it feels normal, just a father with his son, watching TV in the living room. But then the grip tightens. The sound of a distant thunderstorm rolls in, subtle and eerie, increasing as his father’s hands start to wander, slowly, deliberately, touching places they shouldn’t.

THABISO’S FATHER

(in a low voice)

Just sit still fana, ra tshamika fela.

[Just sit still boy, we’re just playing.]

Thabiso feels frozen. He doesn’t understand what’s happening, but it feels wrong. His body tenses, but he doesn’t move. His father’s words are heavy, and the boy remains silent, unable to make sense of the fear building inside him.

CUT TO

INT. THABISO’S BEDROOM - NIGHT (PRESENT DAY)

Thabiso snaps back to the present. His hands tremble, his chest tight, his thoughts spiraling. The memories he’s tried so hard to bury keep flooding back. He gets up, pacing the small room, trying to clear his head, but it doesn’t help.

THABISO(V.O.)

(sobbing and pleading)

Please stop...I don’t want to go back, we are fine now, JUST STOP THINKING!

He stops in front of the dresser, staring at his reflection in the mirror. Slowly, almost subconsciously, he rolls up the sleeve of his shirt, revealing smooth deep greyish lines on his forearm.

CUT TO

FLASHBACK - INT. BATHROOM - NIGHT (YEARS AGO)

A teenage Thabiso, 15, stands in the bathroom. His eyes are red from crying. In his hand, he holds a jagged piece of broken plastic, a shard from a chair he had shattered in anger earlier. His father’s touch, his voice, everything about that man had suffocated him for so long, and tonight it felt unbearable.

THABISO(V.O.)

(his hands shaking)

It’s fine, this will help, I mean, ha madi atswa, le yena otlo tswa mohona, maybe I won’t feel him anymore, atleast ke tlohotlwa bohloko bannete, eseng yena.

[It’s fine, this will help, I mean when the blood leaves my body, he will leave too, I won’t feel him anymore, this time I’ll feel real pain, not him.]

Without thinking, he presses the shard against his forearm. The sharp pain cuts through the numbness, a moment of control in the chaos of his mind.

CUT TO

INT. THABISO'S BEDROOM - NIGHT (PRESENT DAY)

THABISO(V.O.)

(looking at his arm, his face filled with regret)

Why did I let him, I could have stopped him, but NO I was too young, I didn't know what was happening, how could I have known, mama should have noticed, maybe I should have told her...

CUT TO

FLASHBACK - INT. KITCHEN - DAY (YEARS AGO)

A teenage Thabiso walks into the kitchen, trying to act normal. His mother is at the counter, chopping vegetables for dinner. The loud sound of the knife and cutting board clashing fills the room. As he reaches for a glass in the cabinet, his sleeve lifts slightly, exposing the fresh cut on his arm and the sound abruptly goes still.

His mother sees the wound immediately, her eyes narrowing in concern.

THABISO'S MOTHER

(worried)

What happened?

His mind races for an answer.

THABISO

Ke wile, neke dlala ka stulo, then sa robeha kawa.

[I fell outside when I was playing with the plastic chair.]

His mother looks at him for a long moment, her expression a mixture of doubt and concern. She doesn't press further, but the tension hangs in the air.

THABISO'S MOTHER

(softly)

Utihlokomele next time,kauri o tla ikgobatsa go feta mo.

[Be careful next time, you may hurt yourself even more.]

Thabiso nods quickly, the lie burning in his throat. He pulls away from her and retreats to his room, his heart heavy with shame.

CUT TO

INT. THABISO'S BEDROOM - NIGHT (PRESENT DAY)

THABISO(V.O.)

(tears flooding his face)

I should have told her, why did I keep quiet...

CUT TO

EXT. EMPTY STREET - DAY

It's the next morning, Thabiso walks briskly down a quiet street. It's the early hours of the morning, the sound of his steps and heavy breathing fills the street. His breath quickens, and he keeps glancing behind as if someone is watching him.

THABISO(V.O.)

I'm being followed. Someone is behind me, I can feel it.

He turns around sharply, but no one's there. The street is deserted, only shadows from streetlights flickering around him.

THABISO (V.O.)

Don't look. Just keep walking. It's not real. It's all in your head.

But then, a strong cigarette smell lingers in the air, the smell feels so familiar and too close. Thabiso freezes. His heart races as the smell gets stronger. He looks around but there is still no one there, he speeds up, but it seems like he is chasing the smell.

THABIS0(V.O.)

I can’t outrun it. Yang atamela.

[I can’t outrun it. It’s getting closer.]

A shadow flickers at the edge of his vision, but when he turns to look, there’s no one there. He sprints the last few steps home, slamming the door behind him.

CUT TO

INT. THABISO’S APARTMENT - NIGHT

Thabiso rushes to the bathroom, his body shaking. He turns on the tap, splashing his face with water, scrubbing his hands vigorously. The sound of water dripping in slow beats fills the room.

THABISO(V.O.)

(breathing hard)

Everything is fine, ke tlhaloganyo ya gago edlalang ka wena. [Everything is fine, it’s just your mind playing tricks on you.]

Suddenly he feels the cold hands of his father on his back. He looks up at his reflection in the mirror, and for a brief moment, he sees a flicker of his younger self standing behind him, watching.

THABISO(V.O.)

(startled, stepping back)

No, no, no, it’s all in my head.

His younger self is gone, but the unease remains. He looks at his hands which are raw from scrubbing, but he can’t stop. The need to feel clean consumes him.

THABISO(V.O.)

(breathing heavily)

I can’t let it come back, I can’t let him take control of me again, he’s dead, HE is DEAD!

He says as he looks at his reflection in the mirror.

CUT TO

INT. THABISO’S BEDROOM - LATE NIGHT

The room is dark, filled with a low ominous hum and a faint ticking clock. Thabiso feels the presence of someone watching him. The clock reads 1:43 AM.

THABISO(V.O.)

I can feel him, he’s here, waiting for me to close my eyes, but I won’t this time, I’m not a kid anymore.

A creaking sound echoes faintly in the background. He sits up quickly, turning on the light. His breath catches as he sees a shadow standing by the doorway.

THABISO

(panicking)

Who’s there?

The shadow doesn’t move. It just watches. Thabiso stares at it, terrified, but he doesn’t run, he gets out of bed and steps toward it, but as he reaches out, the shadow disappears, and silence fills the room once more.

THABISO(V.O.)

(reassuring himself, trying to ignore what he knows he is feeling)

I’m losing it. There’s no one here, no one’s out to get me, I’m just overthinking it.

Then suddenly a deafening alarm tone shatters the silence, signalling him that it’s time to start studying for his upcoming test.

CUT TO

INT. BATHROOM - DAY

It’s 3 am, Thabiso hasn’t even read a single word off his notes, he sits in the bathtub, fully clothed. The water rises around him, but he doesn’t seem to notice. His breathing is shallow, his eyes held the horizon, as though seeing something miles beyond the present moment.

THABISO(V.O.)

Why...why do I feel his weight, the way he smelled. It’s not my mind, it’s not the water, It’s not Coach. It’s the weight of what happened.

He stares blankly ahead, his gaze unfocused. Suddenly, a subtle movement catches his eye, a shadow stretching towards him, as it gets closer, a non-diegetic thunderclap begins, his eyes widen with fear as he sees someone he was not expecting, he sees his younger self standing in the bathroom doorway. The boy is bruised, his eyes wide with sadness, watching Thabiso intently.

YOUNGER THABISO

(softly)

Look at you, you’re still weak, why didn’t you stop him?

Thabiso gasps, backing up against the wall of the tub.

THABISO

(stuttering, his voice trailing off slowly)

You’re not real, you’re not real, you’re not real.

YOUNGER THABISO

(stepping closer)

You let him hurt us, you DIDN’T save me.

The water rises, submerging Thabiso’s legs, but he doesn’t move. Younger Thabiso steps closer until he’s right beside the tub. Non-diegetic eerie, sombre music begins softly.

THABISO

(his voice shaking and breaking)

What do you want?

YOUNGER THABISO

I want you to save me.

Thabiso’s breath quickens as the younger version of himself climbs into the tub. The water ripples as young Thabiso crouches beside him, the weight of the trauma almost tangible.

THABISO

Save you from what?

YOUNGER THABISO

From you, can’t you see what you’re doing to me, you keep on carrying me around, you’re taking me everywhere with you, I need you to let me go because I’m not good for you, LET ME GO!

THABISO

What do you mean? You’re me, how do you expect me to let you go? You’re inside me!

YOUNGER THABISO

(with a sorrowful gaze)

You just don’t get it...

Younger Thabiso reaches out and places his hand on older Thabiso’s shoulder and all Thabiso has been trying to forget replays in his head, feeling helpless and numb Thabiso freezes, his body tenses and doesn’t move. As the music becomes louder, Thabiso’s eyes lock with his younger self’s, but there is no malice only sadness, as if this moment was inevitable. With one push, his younger self pulls him under completely, the water swallowing them both. The world fades to black.

THE END